

A person wearing a straw hat and a white shirt is sitting on a grey lounge chair in a garden. A large, light-colored patio umbrella is open over them. In the foreground, there are two rolled-up blue and white towels, a bottle of champagne, a glass of champagne, and some fruit on a tray. The background shows a wooden fence and some green bushes. The text "Getting out of town" is written in a large, white, cursive font across the middle of the image.

Getting out of town

Escaping the capital city for the weekend is one of the highlights every Londoner looks forward to once in a while. With the long, sun-drenched season settling in, *British Travel Journal's* London insider heads to Surrey for a classic quiet countryside weekend.

Text by Emma Henderson



The feeling of easy escape – that thrilling sense of freedom when you trade city pavements for winding country paths – is something we all cherish, no matter where we call home. For me, as a Londoner, part of the capital's appeal is precisely this: knowing how effortlessly I can leave. Contradictory as it may sound, whether it's boarding a fast train for the mountains of Snowdonia, driving down for the dramatic coasts of Cornwall, or merely whizzing around the M25 to the Home Counties, the ease of escape brings a sense of relief. We all love to 'get out' of the city, and it's this short break – one that allows us a change of scenery, connects us to nature, and slows us down – that ultimately draws us back to city life.

And for me, that's exactly what the summer season calls for more than any other time. As temperatures climb and the long, warm season gets underway, I'm always looking for where my next short trip will be.

Usually, it's Cornwall, where coastal winds help keep temperatures slightly cooler, and the allure of the sea is just too much. But, it's not always easy to do in a weekend, as more time can be spent in the car on the motorway than anyone really wants. So instead, I head to Surrey to explore a lesser-known corner of the Home Counties, one where peace and proximity perfectly align for a restorative break.

Driving from London, quite quickly the M25 fades, giving way to winding Surrey lanes lined with oak trees and hedgerows, the odd horse out on a hack and cyclists pedalling for pleasure instead of commuting. I'm now in village territory with greenery outweighing man-made materials, and I know I'm in the English countryside heartlands of the home counties as I pass by a cricket match, full of players in their cricket whites on a perfectly luscious green pitch.

It's a sign that I'm entering a slower pace here as I near Whitmoor Farm, where I'm staying. It's less than an hour from the capital, hidden among 38 acres of woodland and open grassland between Guildford and Woking.



‘I imagine them coming out onto the balcony and it being the perfect picture, says general manager Jacques. Looking up, I see exactly what he means, and it could easily resemble a scene from a rendition of *Romeo and Juliet*.’

Whitmoor Farm is all about space and quietness, with woodlands on the edge of the estate with winding paths that fold into open pasture where children can play, and where birds wheel overhead. In the early evening, the fields glow gold in the fading light.

At Whitmoor, there's a handful of renovated cottages, blending rustic charm with contemporary comfort, which had a former life as stables – not that you'd really know from inside. I'm staying in the Eagle's Nest Cottage, a one-bed self-catering cottage that sits around the outside heated pool.

There's also Luxury Cottage, sleeping eight, Weston Cottage, sleeping six and the Pool House, which sleeps four. The most recent to be updated have a scandi-inspired design, with cool-toned wood, soft linen textures, and dried grasses that add to the calming, nature-led palette.

Later this summer, Whitmoor will be launching John Paul Getty Cottage and Koch Cottage, both sleeping eight. As I head off, a big family gathering is taking place on the grounds, with the family having booked out the entire farm, with many coming together from America and further afield.

The jewel in the crown is The Barn (sleeps eight), which has a dramatic double-height living space (that's perfect for a family gathering) and is framed by original wooden beams. "This is where brides get ready when we have weddings here," explains general manager Jacques Nel Van Niekerk, as we stand beneath the vaulted ceiling.

"I imagine them coming out onto the balcony and it being the perfect picture," he says. Looking up, I see exactly what he means, and it could easily resemble a scene from a rendition of *Romeo and Juliet*.



And that Shakespearean timeframe isn't out of kilter either, as Whitmoor Farm sits within one of Surrey's most historically significant estates, Sutton Place, and one of the earliest Renaissance-style homes in England. The land once formed part of the vast Tudor estate of Sir Richard Weston, courtier to King Henry VIII, who was granted the manor of Sutton in 1521.

Centuries later, the estate was famously home to the American oil magnate J. Paul Getty (the grandfather of the founder of Getty Images), who spent many years living nearby at Sutton Place. Yet despite its remarkable heritage, Whitmoor Farm feels refreshingly relaxed rather than formal, since the Morgan family acquired the estate two decades ago.

Come morning, as the sun is already shining, the pool is calling out to me, so of course I take a dip. It is heated, but not covered, and once I get over the initial chilly dunk, it's a serene way to start the morning. Afterwards, we cook our breakfast and have it outside by the pool, listening to the birds, and it's a reminder of how well Surrey has long perfected the art of the gentle weekend escape. 🍷

→ Self-catering doubles from £188; whitmoorfarm.com



What to do nearby:

- There is one of England's most picturesque villages, with ivy-covered cottages, quiet lanes and a tiny stream winding through the centre and is just seven miles away. Film lovers may recognise it from *The Holiday* and the fourth *Bridget Jones* film.
- Equally charming is Ripley, just five miles by car, which is home to independent cafés, antique shops and traditional pubs.
- Guildford Castle, thought to have been built by William the Conqueror after the 1066 invasion, is just 4 miles away. Climb the Great Tower for stunning views of historic Guildford and its beautifully kept gardens.
- For walkers, the surrounding countryside is a gift. Whitmoor Common Nature Reserve offers peaceful woodland trails directly from the doorstep, while longer rambles along the North Downs Way reveal some of Surrey's most beautiful scenery. Or talk the towpaths around the River Wey offer scenic waterside walking and cycling routes, with narrowboats drifting peacefully through the countryside.
- Of course, pubs are plenty around the Surrey Hills. The Percy Arms in nearby Chilworth is exactly the sort of place to end up after a walk, with a large pub garden in summer and roaring fires in winter, along with low wooden beams and excellent seasonal food.

HADESTOWN

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Hadestown is now in its third celebrated year at the Lyric Theatre in London's West End. Enjoy the record-breaking sensation in which a song can change your fate. Originating as an indie theatre project and acclaimed album, *Hadestown* has been transformed into a wonderful theatrical experience. Let the musical performance take you on an unforgettable journey to the underworld and back, intertwining two mythic love stories: that of young dreamers Orpheus and Eurydice, and that of King Hades and his wife Persephone. This deeply resonant and defiantly hopeful production invites you to imagine how the world could be.

Blending American songwriting traditions, from indie folk to pop, blues, and New Orleans-inspired jazz, *Hadestown* has music, lyrics, and book by acclaimed Tony® and Grammy®-winning singer-songwriter and BBC Radio 2 Folk Award-winner Anais Mitchell. Don't miss this critically acclaimed production during your next London visit. ♦



HOW TO BOOK TICKETS

With over 140,000 more tickets released, bookings for *Hadestown* are now available through to June 2027.

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